

LINE BY LINE An improvised free school for poor children under a bridge in Delhi

AMARJEET KUMAR SINGH/GETTY IMAGES

'E' FOR EDUCATION

The expanded e-Vidya scheme sees a big push in the education budget. Can it bridge the divide?

By SHELLY ANAND

While making the Budget 2022-23 announcements for the education sector, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman admitted that due to the pandemic-induced closure of schools, children, particularly in the rural areas and those from the weaker sections, have lost almost two years of formal education. "To build a resilient mechanism for education delivery, the 'one class-one TV channel' programme of PM e-Vidya will be expanded from 12 to 200 TV channels. This will enable all states to provide supplementary education in regional languages for Classes 1 to 12," she said.

With special emphasis on reducing the learning gap and making digital education feasible, the minister announced an 11.9 per cent increase in the financial allocation for the education sector—from Rs 93,234 crore in 2021-22 to Rs 1.04 lakh crore in 2022-23. The minister also announced the opening of a digital university for quality universal education and setting up of skilling e-labs.

₹1.04 LAKH CRORE

Budgetary allocation for the education sector in 2022-23, a hike of 11.9%

₹10,233.7 CRORE

Funds alloted for PM Poshan (the renamed school mid-day meal scheme) in 2022-23 is Rs 750 crore less than previous year

It's the decision to expand the 'one class, one TV channel' programme, though, that has garnered most attention. Launched originally in May 2020, the expanded initiative will make it possible for each state to deliver classes in regional languages through dedicated TV channels. The full course will be covered just like in school and each subject class will have its own timings and QR-coded books. Currently, the 12 existing channels (one dedicated to each Class, from 1 to 12) telecast curriculum-based educational content in Hindi and English, developed by NCERT and other academic agencies. Students don't need an Internet connection and can watch the content just like other TV channels.

The pandemic has been a major setback for the education system in India, with school-going children, particularly from the rural pockets of the country, the most affected given the lag in infrastructure, internet facilities and the lack of familiarity with digital technology among the teachers and students. Praveen Raju, co-chair, FICCI ARISE, and founder, Suchitra Academy, says, "The most commendable part of the e-Vidya programme is the high-quality edutainment content, which will be compatible with mobile phones, laptops, radio as well as TV. It will benefit students living in marginalised areas where online education is still a dream." The access for students will be facilitated through e-content in all spoken languages with the motto of not leaving a single learner behind.

Meanwhile, there has been some criticism too. The National Scheme of Incentive to Girls, a scholarship scheme for female students from the SC/ ST communities and rural areas, gets no financial support this year; so too the Padhna Likhna Abhiyaan, a basic literacy scheme for adults. More importantly, funds have been cut for PM Poshan (the renamed mid-day meal scheme in schools), which gets Rs 10,233.7 crore, Rs 750 crore less than last year. ■